

Functions

5.1 Basics of a Function

Functions represent one of the most important concepts that are used in any type of programming environment. They are basically blocks of code that are used for carrying out specific tasks and can be reused many times in the program. In the case of Flash ActionScripting, generally two types of functions are found. They are the methods and function closures. Depending on the context in which a function is defined, it can be called a function or a method closure. The function can be called a method only if it is defined as part of a class definition or it is attached to an instance of an object. It is called a function closure if it is declared in any other manner.

Calling Functions

A function may be called in many ways. One way of calling a function is by using its identifier followed by a parenthesis operator (). This parenthesis operator is mainly used to enclose function parameters that the programmer wants to send to the function. Consider the example given below. Here the `trace()` function, which is a top level function in the Flash Player API, is used.

```
trace("Use trace to help debug your script");
```

When a function without parameters is called, an empty pair of parenthesis is used. For instance the user can use the `Math.random()` method which does not take any parameters but generates random numbers. This is shown by an example given below.

```
var randomNum:Number = Math.random();
```

Defining Functions

In Flash ActionScripting, there are two ways in which a function can be defined. One way of defining a function is by using the